

# **PRODUCT DESIGN**

## **COMPREHEND**

### **Clarifying Questions & Answers:**

- **Product Type:** New standalone product with potential to integrate into existing home-service platforms (e.g., Snabbitt) as a go-to-market strategy for faster validation
- **Objective:** Adoption - getting users to complete their first booking
- **Target Market:** India, Tier-1 cities
- **Platform:** Mobile app
- **Technical/Operational Constraints:** Supply-side onboarding (finding and vetting home cooks) and unit economics (cook serves limited households per day) are key operational risks to design around
- **Timeline/Budget:** No specific constraints assumed

### **Define Problem Space:**

#### **→ Current Alternatives:**

- ◆ Word of mouth and personal networks
- ◆ Society communities and platforms like MyGate (limited to local, informal pool)
- ◆ Food delivery apps like Swiggy/Zomato (including their "home-style" food options)
- ◆ Hiring through domestic help agencies (unorganized, no tech layer)

#### **→ Why is this a problem?**

- ◆ Working professionals struggle to find reliable cooks matching their schedule, dietary preferences, and cuisine needs
- ◆ The discovery pool through word of mouth is extremely small and luck-dependent
- ◆ No verification, ratings, or trust layer exists for home cooks
- ◆ People who can afford to pay and want healthy home-cooked meals either compromise or depend on food delivery which lacks transparency
- ◆ Parents juggling work and children's nutrition have no reliable, flexible solution

#### **→ What's broken in current solutions?**

- ◆ Food delivery apps offer convenience but not transparency food cooked in your kitchen, with your ingredients, in front of you is a level of trust no delivery app can match. We're not saying outside food is bad; home-cooked is simply a different, more transparent category
- ◆ No organized product exists that connects urban households with on-demand or flexible home cooks
- ◆ The entire market is unstructured no discovery, no reviews, no scheduling, no standardization

**Problem Statement:** *"We are solving for the lack of an organized, reliable way for urban Indian households to discover and book home cooks because current alternatives are fragmented and informal, and food delivery, while convenient, cannot match the transparency, personalization, and health assurance of meals cooked in your own kitchen."*

## IDENTIFYING USERS & USER JOURNEY

### User Segments:

1. **Working Professionals & Parents** – Aged 25-45, living in Tier-1 Indian cities. Dual-income couples or single working individuals in their own apartments. Time-starved, working 5+ days a week. They value health, want home-cooked meals but lack time and energy to cook. Currently depend on food delivery, word of mouth for cooks, or skipping proper meals altogether. High frequency need (daily), strong ability to pay.
2. **Food Enthusiasts with Disposable Income** – People who love eating diverse cuisines, have the money to spend, but don't cook themselves. Outside food has stopped exciting them. They want someone to come and cook varied, exciting meals at home. Need driver is experience and variety, not time scarcity.
3. **Elderly Living Alone** – Aged 60+, children have moved to other cities. Physically unable to cook daily, want simple, comforting home-cooked meals. It's a care and wellbeing use case more than convenience.

**Selected User:** *"I will focus on Working Professionals & Parents because they represent the largest addressable segment in Tier-1 Indian cities, face this problem with the highest frequency (5+ days a week), have strong willingness and ability to pay, and have the lowest barrier to adoption since their need is immediate and recurring."*

## Current User Journey (Working Professional, no product exists):

1. **Trigger** - End of workday, tired, realizes they need a meal. Or morning rush, needs to plan lunch/dinner for family.
2. **Evaluate Options** - Mentally weighs choices: cook myself, order from Swiggy/Zomato, rely on regular cook if they have one, or eat out.
3. **If cooking themselves** - Check kitchen for ingredients, realize something is missing, spend 45-60 minutes cooking after an exhausting day, then clean up. Repeating this 5 days a week is unsustainable.
4. **If ordering food delivery** - Open Swiggy/Zomato, browse options, pick something labeled "healthy" or "home-style," wait 30-40 minutes, eat. But left wondering how it was actually made, whether it's genuinely healthy, and feeling guilty about eating out daily.
5. **If they have a regular cook** - Depend on one person who comes at a fixed time. When the cook doesn't show up (which happens frequently), there's no backup. The cook has a limited repertoire, and finding a replacement is a painful multi-week process.
6. **If searching for a new cook** - Ask friends, post in society WhatsApp groups, check MyGate, get a phone number, call and negotiate, do a trial, hope it works. Entire process takes days to weeks with no guarantee of quality or reliability.

## Where Friction Happens:

- **Pain Point 1: Discovery is broken** - No structured platform exists to find home cooks. It's entirely word of mouth, luck-dependent, and limited to a tiny local pool.
- **Pain Point 2: No trust or verification layer** - When you do find a cook, there are no reviews, ratings, background checks, or any way to assess quality before committing.
- **Pain Point 3: Zero flexibility in timing** - Regular cooks operate on fixed schedules. Working professionals with unpredictable work hours, late meetings, travel, or shifting routines have no way to book a cook that fits *their* availability. The cook's schedule dictates the household, not the other way around.
- **Pain Point 4: No backup or on-demand option** - When the regular cook doesn't show up, there's no fallback other than ordering delivery. No platform offers an immediate replacement.
- **Pain Point 5: Limited variety** - Regular cooks typically know a narrow set of dishes. Users who want diverse cuisines, specific dietary meals (high protein, low carb, regional specialties) have no way to find specialized cooks.
- **Pain Point 6: Health compromise becomes the default** - Users who genuinely care about eating healthy are forced to either trust delivery apps' "healthy" labels

blindly or spend time cooking themselves. There's no solution that gives them health-conscious, home-cooked meals without requiring their own time and effort.

## REPORT NEEDS

**For Working Professionals & Parents in Tier-1 Indian cities, the key needs are:**

→ **Need: A quick, reliable way to discover and book verified home cooks.**

**Why it exists:** Today, finding a home cook is entirely unstructured word of mouth, society groups, MyGate with no ratings, reviews, or background verification. Every hire is a gamble that takes days to weeks. Users need a platform that lets them find a trusted cook quickly, the way they find a cab on Uber or a salon service on Urban Company.

→ **Need: Flexibility to book a cook on their own schedule, with a reliable backup.**

**Why it exists:** Regular cooks work on fixed timings that don't align with unpredictable work schedules late meetings, travel, shifting hours. When the cook doesn't show up, there's no fallback. Users need the ability to book a cook when *they* need one, and have an instant replacement option when plans fall through.

→ **Need: Healthy, varied, and personalized home-cooked meals without spending their own time.**

**Why it exists:** Regular cooks have limited repertoires. Food delivery claims to be healthy but offers no transparency. Users who care about specific diets, diverse cuisines, or child-friendly nutrition are forced to either cook themselves or compromise. They need access to cooks with specific specializations without having to hunt for them through informal channels.

**Core Insight:** *"The core issue is that urban professionals need home-cooked meals to be as convenient, reliable, and flexible as any other on-demand service but today, the entire home cook ecosystem remains informal, rigid, and unorganized, forcing users to compromise daily on health, time, or quality."*

## PRIORITIZE

**Evaluation:**

| Need                                  | Frequency   | Severity    |
|---------------------------------------|-------------|-------------|
| Discovery & booking of verified cooks | Medium      | High        |
| Flexibility in scheduling with backup | High        | Medium-High |
| Health, variety & personalization     | Medium-High | Medium      |

**Selected Problem:** *"I will focus on solving for on-demand, reliable access to verified home cooks combining discovery and flexible scheduling as one integrated problem. Discovery is the foundation (high severity without it, nothing works), and flexible booking is the daily value driver (high frequency it's what keeps users coming back). Together they form the core product proposition. Health, variety, and personalization will be addressed as a feature layer within the solution, not as a separate problem to solve."*

Think of it like Uber the product simultaneously solved "find a cab" (discovery) and "get one when you need it" (on-demand flexibility). Nobody would say Uber solved two problems. It solved one: getting a ride when you need one. The discovery and the scheduling are inseparable parts of that.

**Why this matters for adoption:** A working professional will download and try this app when they believe they can find a trusted cook *and* book them at a time that actually works. Neither alone is enough to drive first-time usage.

## SOLUTIONS

**For the problem:** On-demand, reliable access to verified home cooks with flexible scheduling

### **Solution 1: Scheduled Booking with Time Slots**

How it works: Users book a cook by the previous night or early morning for the next day. They select time slots (1-hour or 2-hour sessions), specify cuisine preferences, dietary needs, and number of people. The platform assigns a suitable cook. If cooking runs over, a 30-minute

extension is available at additional cost hard capped since the cook has their next appointment. This is the primary, everyday use case.

### **Solution 2: Instant/Urgent Booking at Premium Pricing**

How it works: For users who need a cook immediately regular cook didn't show up, unexpected guests, last-minute plans the app offers on-demand matching within 30 minutes at a surge price. Convenience costs more, but the option exists. This solves the backup problem directly and becomes a strong acquisition hook: "Your cook didn't show up? We've got you covered in 30 minutes."

### **Solution 3: Community Cook Network (Hobbyist Cooks as Supply)**

How it works: Beyond full-time cooks, the platform allows hobbyist cooks people who love cooking, have spare hours, and want to earn side income to sign up. Each cook gets a profile with specializations, cuisine expertise, availability windows, photos of dishes, and user ratings. This expands the supply pool massively, brings cuisine diversity (e.g., a North Indian home cook in Bangalore offering authentic North Indian food), and creates unique emotional value people cooking for others because they genuinely enjoy it.

### **Two Booking Modes (cuts across all solutions):**

1. **Auto-Assign Mode:** User specifies preferences (cuisine, time, dietary needs), the platform matches and assigns the best available cook. Minimal effort, maximum convenience.
2. **Browse & Pick Mode:** User explores cook profiles with ratings, reviews, cuisine specialties, and available time slots. They choose the cook they want. Gives users control and lets them build ongoing relationships with preferred cooks.

**Filtering & Discovery Layer:** Users filter by cuisine type, dietary preferences (high protein, low carb, Jain, vegan), cook ratings, price range, and availability. Cook profiles display specializations, verified reviews, and photos of past dishes.

## **SOLUTIONS**

**For the problem:** On-demand, reliable access to verified home cooks with flexible scheduling

### **Solution 1: Listing & Discovery Platform (The JustDial Model)**

**How it works:** A simple directory where cooks register their profiles with cuisine type, location, and contact details. Users browse, find a cook, and contact them directly to negotiate timing and pricing. The platform only facilitates discovery no in-app booking, no payments, no scheduling. Think Sulekha or JustDial but specifically for home cooks.

### **Solution 2: Subscription-Based Cook Matching Service (The Managed Service Model)**

**How it works:** Users fill a detailed preference form cuisine, dietary needs, schedule, budget. The platform matches them with a dedicated cook who comes daily or on fixed days at a set time. Monthly subscription pricing. If the assigned cook is unavailable, the platform sends a replacement. It's a managed, hands-off service reliable, but rigid. No on-demand flexibility, no choosing your own cook.

### **Solution 3: Full On-Demand Marketplace (The Uber-for-Cooks Model)**

**How it works:** A complete marketplace app with scheduled booking (book by previous night), instant/urgent booking at premium pricing, and a community cook network including hobbyist cooks. Two booking modes auto-assign for convenience or browse-and-pick for control. Cook profiles with ratings, reviews, cuisine specialties, and availability. Filtering by cuisine, dietary preferences, price range. Time-slot-based sessions with paid extension flexibility. Solves discovery, scheduling, backup, and variety in one integrated experience.

## **EVALUATE**

| <b>Criteria</b> | <b>Solution 1: Listing Platform</b>                                                                                                | <b>Solution 2: Subscription Service</b>                                                           | <b>Solution 3: On-Demand Marketplace</b>                                                         |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Impact</b>   | <b>Low</b> - Solves discovery partially but nothing else. User still negotiates, no trust layer, no scheduling                     | <b>Medium</b> - Solves reliability and daily meals, but no flexibility or variety                 | <b>High</b> - Solves discovery, scheduling, backup, variety, and trust in one experience         |
| <b>Effort</b>   | <b>Low</b> - Simple to build, minimal tech                                                                                         | <b>Medium</b> - Needs matching algorithm, cook management, replacement logistics                  | <b>High</b> - Complex marketplace with booking engine, payments, profiles, ratings               |
| <b>Risk</b>     | <b>High</b> - No differentiation from existing WhatsApp groups or MyGate. Users leave the platform after getting the cook's number | <b>Medium</b> - Rigid model limits addressable market. Users who want flexibility won't subscribe | <b>Medium</b> - Supply-Side onboarding is the main risk, but community cook network mitigates it |

**Best Solution:** *"I recommend Solution 3: the Full On-Demand Marketplace because it is the only approach that solves the complete problem discovery, trust, flexible scheduling, instant backup, and cuisine variety in one integrated product. Solution 1 is too thin and offers no real value beyond what WhatsApp groups already do. Solution 2 solves reliability but kills the flexibility that working professionals need most. Solution 3 requires higher effort to build, but the impact justifies it, and the community cook network strategy de-risks the supply challenge by opening the platform to hobbyist cooks alongside professionals."*

**Trade-off acknowledged:** *"The primary trade-off is build complexity and supply-side cold start. We mitigate this by launching with a focused MVP in one or two Tier-1 cities, onboarding hobbyist cooks alongside professional ones to build supply faster, and using instant booking as the acquisition hook to drive first-time usage."*

## **MVP DEFINITION**

### **Core Features (Must-Have for Launch):**

1. **Cook Onboarding & Profiles** - Verified cook profiles with cuisine specializations, availability windows, experience, and a brief bio. This is the foundation without supply, nothing works.
2. **Scheduled Booking with Time Slots** - Users book by the previous night or early morning for the next day. Select 1-hour or 2-hour sessions. This is the core daily use case.
3. **Auto-Assign Booking Mode** - User specifies cuisine, time, and dietary needs. Platform matches the best available cook. Keeps the first experience simple and low-effort for the user.
4. **Cuisine & Dietary Filters** - Filter by cuisine type (North Indian, South Indian, Chinese, Continental) and dietary preferences (vegetarian, non-vegetarian, Jain, high protein, low carb). Essential for personalization from day one.
5. **In-App Payments** - Session-based pricing. Transparent pricing shown before booking. No negotiation, no cash dependency.
6. **Ratings & Reviews** - Post-session rating and review for every booking. Builds the trust layer that doesn't exist today and helps future users make informed decisions.

### **Nice-to-Have (V1.1 Post Validation):**



1. **Browse & Pick Mode** - Let users explore cook profiles and choose their preferred cook. Requires a denser supply pool to work well, so better suited for after initial supply is built.
2. **Instant/Urgent Booking at Surge Pricing** - On-demand matching within 30 minutes. Requires high supply density in a geography to guarantee availability. Strong feature, but premature for MVP.
3. **Community/Hobbyist Cook Sign-ups** - Opening the platform to non-professional cooks. Powerful for supply expansion and cuisine diversity, but adds verification complexity. Launch with vetted professional cooks first, expand later.
4. **Time Extension Feature** - 30-minute paid extension during a session. Adds operational complexity around cook scheduling. Can be introduced once booking patterns are understood.
5. **Favourite Cooks & Repeat Booking** - Let users save preferred cooks and rebook them directly. A retention feature - meaningful only after users have completed enough sessions to have preferences.

**MVP Focus:** *"We will launch with scheduled booking and auto-assigned verified cooks in one Tier-1 city (Bangalore) to validate whether working professionals will consistently book home cooks through a structured platform and whether the session-based model delivers a reliable, satisfying experience for both users and cooks."*

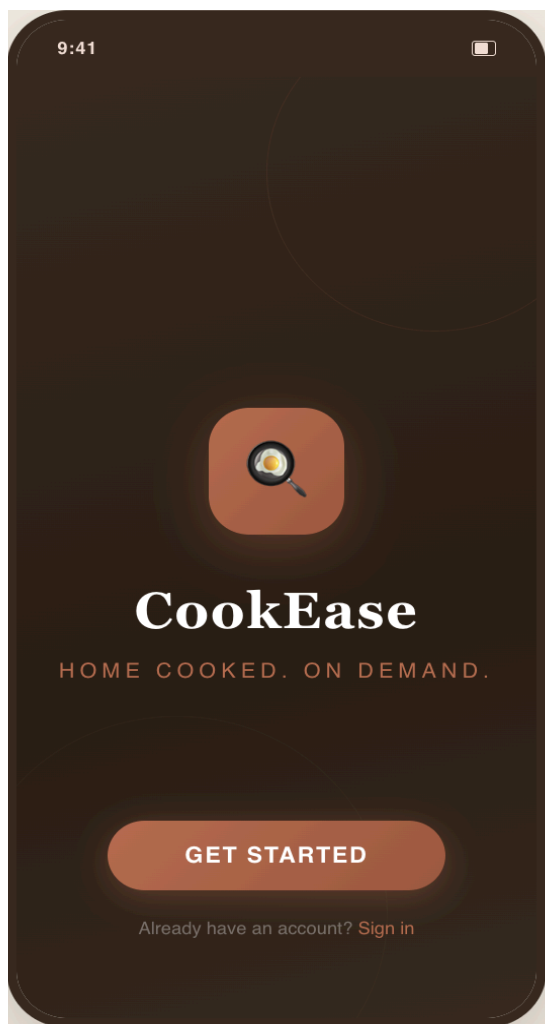
## SUCCESS METRICS

**North Star Metric:** Number of users completing 6+ bookings within their first 30 days (roughly 1.5 times per week signals the product is moving from trial to routine, accounting for the trust-building phase of a new product category)

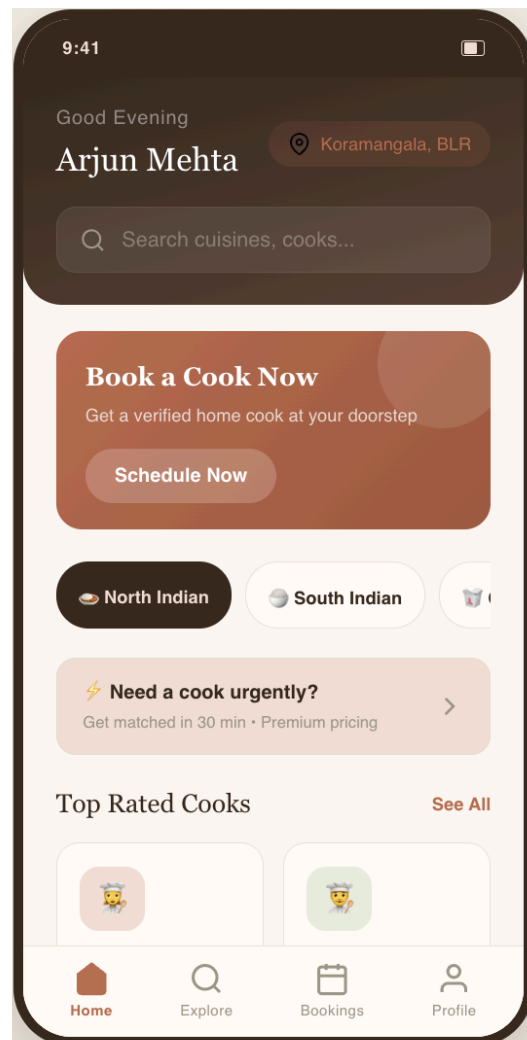
### Supporting Metrics:

- **First booking conversion rate** - % of users who sign up and complete their first session. Measures onboarding friction and initial trust barrier. Target: 30%+
- **Week 1 to Week 2 retention** - % of users who book in week 1 and book again in week 2. Earliest signal of habit formation. Target: 40%+
- **Cook utilization rate** - % of available cook slots that get booked. Measures supply-demand balance and marketplace health. Target: 60%+
- **Average session rating** - Post-session user rating. Quality indicator for cook performance and overall experience. Target: 4.2+ out of 5

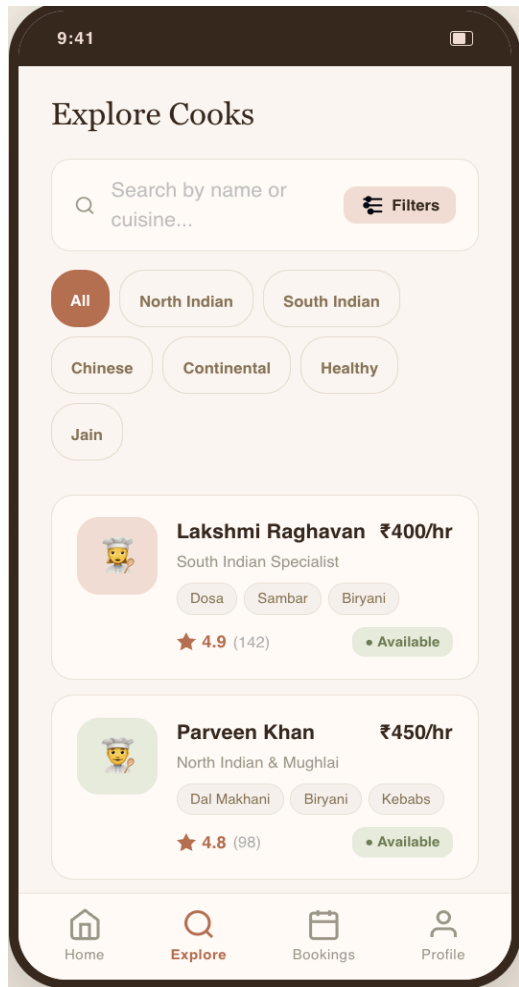
- **Repeat cook rate** - % of bookings where the user chose the same cook again. Signals trust, satisfaction, and relationship building between user and cook. Target: 35%+
- **Time from sign-up to first booking** - Measures how quickly new users convert. Lower is better - ideally within 24 hours of sign-up



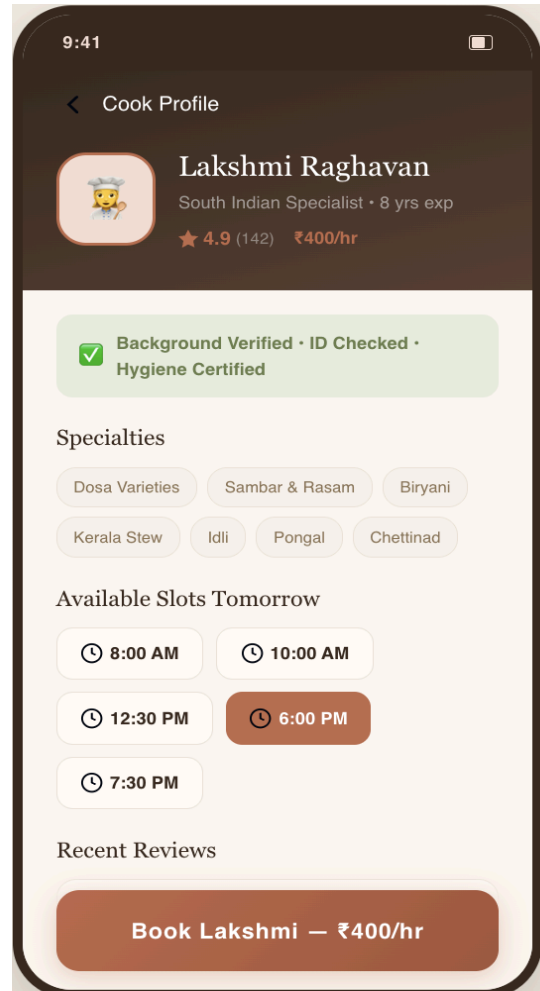
**SPLASH SCREEN**



**HOME SCREEN**



COOK SCREEN



COOK PROFILE

9:41

<

Book a Session



Lakshmi Raghavan

South Indian Specialist

★

4.9

SELECT DATE

Today

10

Tmrw

11

Mon

12

Tue

13

TIME SLOT

8:00 AM

10:00 AM

12:30 PM

6:00 PM

7:30 PM

DURATION

1 Hour

₹400

2 Hours

₹750

Total

₹400

Confirm Booking

BOOKING FLOW

9:41



Booking Confirmed!

Your cook is on the way tomorrow



Lakshmi Raghavan

South Indian Specialist

Date

Sunday, 11 May 2026

Time

6:00 PM — 7:00 PM

Duration

1 Hour

Cuisine

South Indian

Diet

Vegetarian

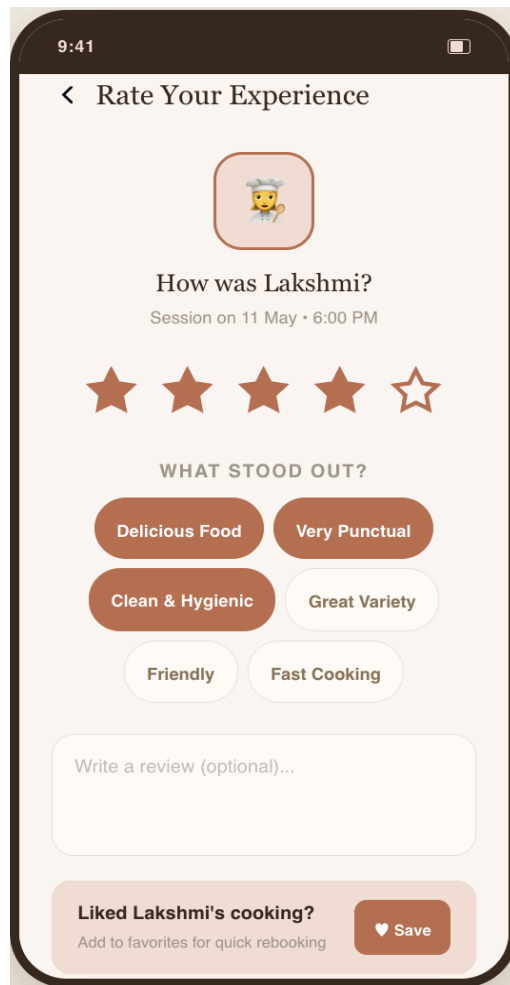
Amount Paid

₹400

 **Tip:** Keep your ingredients ready before the cook arrives. You can share your grocery list via chat.

Back to Home

BOOKING CONFIRMED



## RATE & REVIEW

## SUMMARIZE

We designed CookEase an on-demand home cook marketplace app for working professionals and parents in Tier-1 Indian cities, solving the lack of an organized, reliable, and flexible way to discover and book verified home cooks. The core problem is that home cooking one of the most fundamental daily needs has no structured solution today. Users rely on word of mouth, society groups, and food delivery apps, all of which fail on trust, flexibility, or health transparency.

Our solution is a full on-demand marketplace with three key layers: scheduled booking with time slots (book by previous night for next-day sessions), instant/urgent booking at premium pricing for immediate needs, and a community cook network that brings hobbyist cooks onto the platform for supply diversity and cuisine variety. Users can either let the platform auto-assign a cook based on their preferences, or browse cook profiles with ratings, reviews, and specializations to pick their own.

The MVP launches in one Tier-1 city (Bangalore) with scheduled booking, auto-assign mode, verified cook profiles, cuisine and dietary filters, in-app payments, and a ratings system. Features like browse-and-pick mode, instant booking, community cook sign-ups, and favourite cooks are planned for V1.1 post-validation.

Success is measured by users completing 6+ bookings in their first 30 days, supported by first booking conversion rate, week-over-week retention, cook utilization rate, average session rating, and repeat cook rate.

A viable go-to-market strategy could also include launching as a feature within an existing home-services platform like Snabbit for faster validation and supply-side leverage before scaling independently.